

Unusual additions

Oil paintings from the seventeenth to the nineteenth centuries reveal some complex layer structures – and can include complicated materials. The British artist George Stubbs (1724-1806) used wax-resin mixtures with a drying oil in certain works. Some artists used what are now recognized as unstable materials; Sir Joshua Reynolds (1723-92), for instance, incorporated oil, resin, and bitumen mixtures into his paintings. Gainsborough (1727-88), on the other hand, generally painted fairly thinly, with a drying oil plus pigment mixtures thinned with a solvent.

Research on paintings from the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries is limited, but what we can learn from the state of many works in this period is that the more straightforward the painting techniques and materials are, the more reliable the results.

A change of direction

During the nineteenth century, many artists rejected the constraints of traditional academic practices and moved toward “plein-air” landscape painting from nature. This, combined with new ideas about color and the discovery and development of new pigments, led to the new movement known as Impressionism. Artists such as Monet (1840-1926) and Renoir (1841-1919) made paintings that were often no less complex than oil paintings of the past, but were characterized by a sense of freshness and immediacy that was quite new. Now the character and texture of the individual brushstroke was integral to the look of the work. Color became a focus of painting as never before, with new pigments available to artists and a greater use of bright, saturated primaries and secondaries.

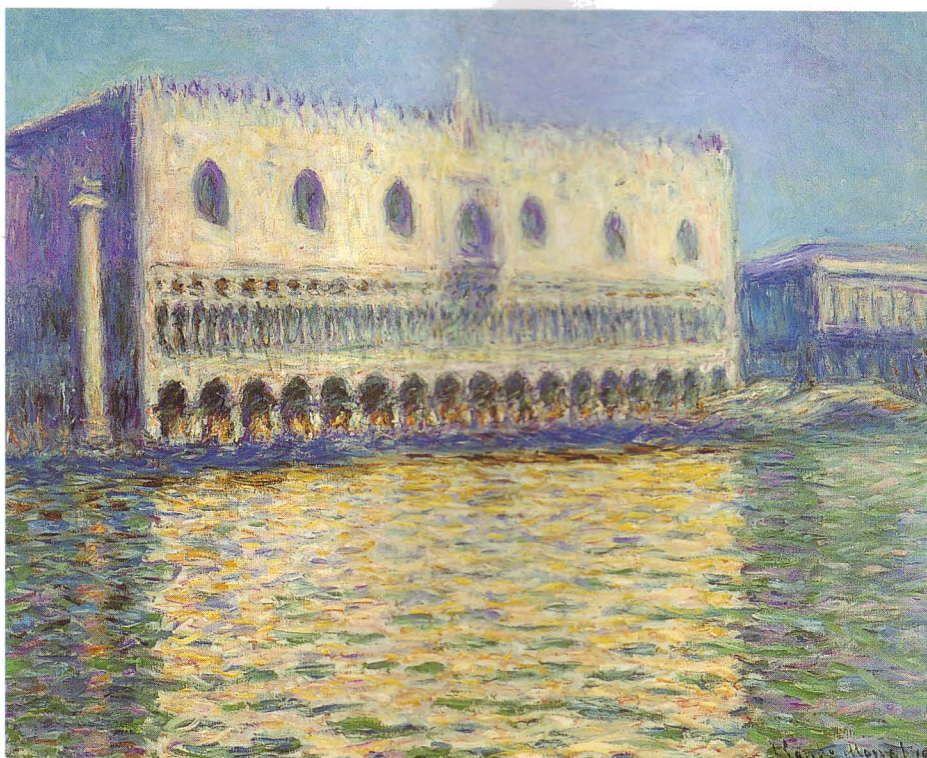
The change in attitude and new approach to oil painting that was first initiated by the Impressionists led to further reevaluations during

the Post-Impressionist years of Gauguin (1848-1903) and Van Gogh (1853-90). The Cubists Braque (1882-1963) and Picasso (1881-1973), and German Expressionists Kirchner (1880-1938) and Nolde (1867-1956), for example, all used the adaptable medium of oil to make great stylistic and technical changes in art. The Surrealists Max Ernst (1891-1976)

and Salvador Dali (1904-89) both used oil in dramatic new ways. Dali reworked the technique of blending oil into soft fluid forms to give expression to his interior thoughts and subconscious desires, while Ernst unlocked his imagination and invented or adapted techniques to give complex textural starting points for his works.



Claude Lorraine, *Echo and Narcissus*, 1644 46½ x 37¼ in (95 x 118 cm)
Like Titian, Claude incorporated stories from Ovid into his serene landscapes. While Titian's work is turbulent, Claude's is calm, suffused with a golden light. The poignancy of self-deception and the failure of human communication is underscored by this soft, warm Arcadian landscape.



Claude Monet, *The Ducal Palace at Venice*, 1908 32 x 38½ in (81 x 98 cm)
Monet relied on color contrasts to create the

brilliant effects of light. Pure yellows and violets and blues and orange-red make this facade glow against the sky and shimmer on the water.